These factors have induced a severe administrative constraint that hampers performance in the Indian state. The best designed policy pathways yield poor outcomes because we lack the institutionalized capabilities to build capable organizations.

Politics without romance

> *When the State trespasses beyond what is legitimately within its province, it just hands over the management from those who are interested in frugal and efficient management to bureaucracy which is untrained and uninterested except in its own survival.*
>
> C. Rajagopalachari [3]

Why do things go wrong? Because we have a rosy-eyed view of the state.

Many decades ago, we used to think of the state as a pristine, benevolent actor who would work for the best interests of the people. Now we think about the *incentives* of politicians and officials, who pursue their own personal objectives. Many mistakes which were made in India, in the early years after 1947, would not have been made if such an unsentimental approach was applied to all policy questions.

We in India have a lot of experience with the working of the state, and are often cynical about the motives of politicians and officials. If employees in the government were benign, we would not have had large numbers of undertrials in jail for periods that exceed the sentence that they would have received if they were pronounced guilty.

This intuition was formalized in the field of ‘Public Choice Theory’ which used economic analysis to think about the objectives of politicians and officials. [4]

The yearning for heroes

> *Andrea: Unhappy is the land that breeds no hero.*
> *Galileo: No, Andrea. Unhappy is the land that needs a hero.*